quail and all kinds of birds; even sparrows and rats, and cats and lizards, all of which are sold in the [city's] market'.

Policing is efficient and few robberies take place. As for punishment, 'for a thief, whatever theft he commits, howsoever little it be, they forthwith cut off a foot and a hand, and if this theft be a great one he is hanged with a hook under his chin'. Ditto with rape and 'other such violence'. Traitors 'are sent to be impaled alive on a wooden stake thrust through the belly, and people of the lower orders, for whatever crime they commit, he forthwith commands to cut off their heads in the market-place, and the same for a murder'. Occasionally, 'when the king so desires, he commands a man to be thrown to the elephants, and they tear him to pieces'. Nuniz reported all this in a matter-of-fact way, perhaps because Vijayanagar was hardly exceptional—medieval European states too doled out appallingly cruel punishments.

The Political Economy of Vijayanagar

My first visit to Hampi left me with many knotty questions: How did the emperors of Vijayanagar rule such a vast region with multiple kingdoms, languages and cultures for nearly three centuries? How did their capital city acquire the riches evident in the gushing accounts of foreign travellers and what political and economic arrangements enabled this? What, if any, deep changes did Vijayanagar Empire bring about in south Indian society?

Among the scholars to tackle such questions is Burton Stein, giving us a rich yet complex portrait of the politics, society and economy of the Vijayanagar Empire in *The New Cambridge History of India: Vijayanagara* (1989). Beginning in pre-Vijayanagar times, Stein postulates the rise of broadly two kinds of settlements in south India by the thirteenth century: one along coastal riverine basins, agriculturally fecund, wealthier, with dense populations and more trades, such as those of the Cholas and Pandyas; the other in the central peninsular uplands, more arid, with limited agriculture, fewer people and a weaker economic base, such as of the Kakatiyas and Hoysalas.

This natural asymmetry, argues Stein, led the latter to desire the former's resources, partly to meet the rising costs and frequency of warfare in this age. And so, in the thirteenth century, 'hardy peasant groups, prevented by